

away from you as well. But even as *what you have* may come and go, *who you are*—your character—will endure.

Boldness, Commitment, and Providence

If things are by nature ephemeral (after all, “you can’t take them with you”), what is it that does matter? What are the characteristics by which we should measure our lives? Surely the nineteenth-century German philosopher Goethe identified one of them: boldness.

*Are you in earnest? Seize this very minute;
What you can do, or dream you can do, begin it;
Boldness has genius, power and magic in it.*

Goethe’s inspirational words inspired a strong amplification from Scottish author W. H. Murray, which I paraphrase here:

Until one is committed, there is hesitancy, the chance to draw back, always ineffectiveness. Concerning all acts of initiative and creation, there is one elementary truth, the ignorance of which kills countless ideas and splendid plans: that the moment one definitely commits oneself, then providence moves too.

A whole stream of events issues from the decision, raising in one’s favor all manner of unforeseen incidents and meetings and material assistance, which no man could have dreamt would have come his way. Whatever you do, or dream you can, begin it. Boldness has genius, power and magic in it. Begin it now.

And so the combination of boldness and commitment magically seems to summon what we might call *providence*.

It is all true, and my own life has been the proof of it, better than any dream. Whenever I have committed myself with boldness,